contagion had spread to them through the interconnections in the financial system. Second, admittedly the market situation was uncertain and unpredictable for advanced economies. But it was even more so for emerging markets which had an additional layer of uncertainty because of not knowing the precise channels through which the contagion would hit them. I suggested that it was not enough that the advanced economies acted in coordination. They had to keep us too in the loop, and on the inner track, and keep our interest in view while shaping their policies.

The G20 delegations, except the 'troika', are typically seated in the alphabetic order of countries. As it happened, the India seat happened to be close to the door, at one edge of the rectangular table. Two minutes into my comments, the door opened, and a man walked in quietly, but with self-assurance, trailed by two burly grey-suited men of stern demeanour. I am sure they tried to be unobtrusive but I was nevertheless distracted by this shuffle so close to my seat and momentarily lost my flow of thought. It struck me that the 'intruder' looked a lot like President Bush. But there had been no indication that he would join us. Besides, how could the President of the United States, by far the most heavily guarded man in the world, walk into a meeting so casually? Wouldn't the famous secret service have subjected the whole building to a high-profile security quarantine before his arrival? Wouldn't there have been security details swarming around the premises since early afternoon?

By now, I was flustered, unsure whether I should just ignore what was happening and continue with my comments or wait until this disturbance had settled down. Although I was not completely sure if it was indeed Bush, by some unconscious instinct I stood up just as he passed behind me. Quite quickly, all the people in the room caught on and stood up too as President Bush walked past two sides of the quadrangle to get to the troika table. I soon realized that everyone at the meeting, including possibly Paulson and Bernanke, was surprised by Bush's unannounced entry.

Hastily, amid mild applause, they made space for him at the troika table, and also found a seat beside him for Secretary Paulson. There was a minute of whispering at the table, possibly briefing the President on what had